quarter of the distance when the company commander was hit in the stomach by an MMG burst. Between them the three men managed to somehow evacuate the mortally wounded officer. At 16,000 feet it required a superhuman effort, yet they managed to get to within 800 metres of the unoccupied Rezang-la Base Camp.

Shaitan Singh was still conscious and coherent. He ordered the men to stop, leave him where he was and return to No. 9 Platoon that was still holding out. Phool Singh and the two men did as they were told. All three of them returned to No. 9 Platoon and were killed shortly afterwards. Major Shaitan Singh remained where his men left him, too weak to move, eventually breathing his last amidst the stony, desolate wilderness. He had done enough to carve not just his own name, but also the names of all the men under his command into the pages of Indian history. Five men had been disabled and captured; two died of their wounds in captivity. One man survived—Havildar Ram Singh. He was badly wounded. The Chinese threw him into a sangar where he lay till 4 in the morning. He then crawled out in full view of the Chinese who watched him go, no one moving to stop him. After a few hours, as he made his way towards the rear, a jeep from his own battalion picked him up. The men in the vehicle were unable to recognize the burnt and bleeding figure, refusing to believe who he was until he actually started naming them. At 9 a.m. Ram Singh was escorted into Battalion HQ—reported to the adjutant, narrating the details of the Rezang-la battle.

THE GORKHAS ON GURUNG HILL

For the Chinese, along with Rezang-la the capture of Gurung Hill was of vital importance. As per their assessment, should they successfully capture the Gurung Hill Ridge, the entire Chushul bowl would then be at their mercy. After the initial barrage lifted, waves of Chinese infantry put in a direct attack from the direction of Black Hill, which had been anticipated by the Indians. However, the Chinese tactic was not for the infantry to grapple with the defenders, but to creep in closer to be able to position their MMGs and mortars that would allow them to blast the defenders in their bunkers, trenches and sangars.

However, the bombardment of Gurung Hill was not a one-sided affair. The three Gurung Hill posts were each held by a platoon of 1/8 GR’s Bravo Company. In addition, Trench Hill was supported by a section of MMGs